

# SEO Fundamentals — Key Points to Remember

A practical cheat-sheet distilled from the Ahrefs “SEO Course for Beginners” (Sam Oh). Use it as a checklist when implementing SEO.

## SEO IN ONE LINE

**SEO = optimizing your content so it gets found in Google’s free (organic) search results.** Google **crawls** the web via links → **indexes** pages → **ranks** them by hundreds of signals. Traffic is free, consistent, and scalable.

## THE 3 THINGS THAT FUNDAMENTALLY DRIVE RANKINGS

1. **Backlinks** — links from other sites = votes of trust. 2. **Search intent** — your page matches what the searcher actually wants. 3. **Content depth** — you fully answer the query (depth ≠ length).

## 01 Keyword Research — pick the right things to target

### 5-point checklist before targeting any keyword

- ☐ **Search demand** — does it get enough monthly searches (search volume)?
- ☐ **Traffic potential** — how much traffic do the current top pages get? (A top page ranks for ~1,000 keywords, so this beats raw volume.)
- ☐ **Business potential** — can you naturally promote your offering? Score 1–3; ignore 0s.
- ☐ **Search intent match** — can your page type actually satisfy the query?
- ☐ **Ranking chance** — can you realistically outrank who’s there now?

### SEARCH INTENT = THE 3 C’S (READ IT OFF THE TOP-RANKING PAGES)

**Content Type** — blog / product / category / landing. · **Content Format** — how-to, step-by-step, listicle, tool/calculator. · **Content Angle** — the hook (e.g. “2024”, “for beginners”, “cheap”).

### How to find keywords

- Start with broad **seed keywords** → phrase/related reports.
- Use **modifiers**: best, top, vs, review (commercial); how, what, guide, tutorial (informational).
- Mine **competitors’ top pages** for topics you’d miss.

### Is it rankable? Ask:

- Do top pages **fail** to match intent? (a weakness = opportunity)
- Can I get **more/better backlinks** than them?
- Is my **site authority (DR)** in a similar range?
- Am I as **topically authoritative** (niche relevance)?

## 02 On-Page SEO — optimize the page itself

### MYTHS — STOP DOING THESE

- Stuffing exact-match keywords.
- Using a keyword “X times” on the page.
- Forcing a minimum word count. (#1 pages exist with 76–628 words.)

### WHAT ACTUALLY MATTERS

- Satisfy **search intent** above all.
- Cover the **subtopics people expect** — learn them from the top 3 pages + a content-gap analysis.

### On-page checklist

- ☐ Target keyword (or close variant) in the **title**.
- ☐ Short, descriptive **URL slug** (words separated by hyphens).
- ☐ Compelling **meta description** (helps click-through, not ranking).
- ☐ **Internal links** to and from other relevant pages.
- ☐ Optimize **images**: descriptive file name + alt text + compression.
- ☐ **Readability**: short sentences/paragraphs, clear subheadings, simple words (~6th-grade level).
- ☐ Optional: Open Graph tags (social sharing) + **schema markup** (rich results).

## 03 Link Building — earn votes of trust (hardest, most important)

| Way to get links                                      | Verdict                                                  |
|-------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Create</b> (directories, comments, profiles)       | Easy but weak.                                           |
| <b>Buy</b> (pay for links)                            | Against Google rules, ~\$353 avg, risky — <b>avoid</b> . |
| <b>Earn</b> (outreach, being a media source, organic) | <b>Best</b> . Mostly via email outreach.                 |

### MINDSET

Link building is **relational** — people link to those they know/trust and when your content genuinely improves theirs. Lead with relevance + value, not a cold favor.

### 5 attributes of a high-quality backlink

- **Relevance** — from a topically related page/site.
- **Authority** — from a strong page/domain (higher DR/UR = more “link power”).
- **Anchor text** — descriptive, natural (Google uses it to understand the target).
- **Followed** (not nofollowed) so it passes value.
- **Placement** — editorially given, inside the body content.

### Indexing gotchas (check these first)

- ❑ No stray **noindex** tags (common leftover after a redesign — can wipe you from Google).
- ❑ **robots.txt** isn't accidentally disallowing important pages.
- ❑ **XML sitemap** exists & is submitted in Google Search Console.
- ❑ **Redirects** point old URLs → current ones.
- ❑ **Canonical tags** resolve duplicates (e.g. http vs https).

### Health best practices

- ❑ Logical **site structure** / hierarchy with internal links.
- ❑ Fast **page speed** — enable caching + compress images.
- ❑ Run **scheduled site audits** to catch broken links, orphan pages, redirect chains, duplicate content.

#### GOLDEN RULE

If a page isn't **indexed**, nothing else matters — indexing is the foundation of everything in SEO.

### ⚡ Implementation order (do it in this sequence)

1. **Verify indexing** — set up Google Search Console, submit a sitemap, confirm key pages are indexed (no rogue noindex/robots blocks).
2. **Keyword map** — run the 5-point checklist; assign one primary intent-matched keyword per page.
3. **On-page pass** — fix titles, slugs, meta descriptions, headings, internal links, image alt text, schema.
4. **Content depth** — make each page fully satisfy intent using the top-3-pages + content-gap method.
5. **Technical health** — page speed, site structure, scheduled audits.
6. **Link building** — earn relevant, authoritative backlinks via outreach (ongoing).
7. **Repeat & monitor** — SEO compounds; review rankings and re-audit regularly.